These views are clearly visible in the Constituent Assembly of India debates from the first two years after Independence. Leaders like Purushottam Das Tandon, Sri Krishna Sinha, Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit and Algurai Shastri championed it to the notion that India would one day lead Asia and that India owed it to the world to work for global peace and prosperity. [10] In Nehru's words India had the 'responsibility of being some kind of guide to vast numbers of people all over the world'.[11]

Even Nehru's main rival as leader of the Congress during the 1930s, Subhas Chandra Bose, held views similar to Nehru with respect to India's role in Asia and its critical geographic location. For Bose, as for Nehru, it was the time for Asia to 'throw off the yoke of thralldom' and 'take her legitimate place in the comity of free nations'. Bose firmly believed that India had 'a mission to fulfil and it is because of this that India still lives'.[12]

The first and only Indian Governor General of independent India, C. Rajagopalachari, spoke about global citizenship and the mission that lay ahead for all Indian citizens. 'Not only the Prime Minister and I, but every enlightened citizen of India must now rise to the full height not only of national citizenship but of world citizenship,' he declared. According to Rajagopalachari, 'The world is watching India with goodwill. Our culture, our philosophy and our outlook on life have a new meaning and a new hope for the nations that have suffered and are suffering in the West. … Being citizens of a free country we should now realize our mission as a nation and our place in world civilization. We must fulfil the obligations that arise out of our place in Asia and our long and intimate connection with the West.'[13]

It seems that a deep-rooted inheritance of India's long civilizational past is the belief that India's civilizational greatness trumps the current status of the Indian state. As a civilization, India historically possessed hard (military and economic) as well as soft (religious and cultural) power not just in its region but also in Asia and beyond. The Indian belief that historical greatness is manifest destiny persisted even during British colonial rule